

The Chess Games, Compared

Nine forms of chess, and the one structural decision that tells each of them apart. Drawn entirely from Culin's own descriptions.

<i>The game</i>	<i>Where</i>	<i>The board</i>	<i>What tells it apart</i>
Chaturanga	Ancient India (entry 45)	64 squares four players, eight men each	The pieces move by the throw of a die. It is the only one of these games in which chance decides what you may move, and it is the strongest evidence Culin has for the whole book.
Chess	Maldiv Islands (entry 47)	64 squares sixteen a side	Identical with the Hindu game and played as in England, but the pieces keep their Persian names — Padshah, Wazir, Phil, Asp, Rukh, Piadah — which is the line of descent audible in the vocabulary.
Chator	Johore, Malay Peninsula (entry 48)	64 squares sixteen a side	Identical again, with the names now Malay: Rajah for the king, Munbrie for the vizier. Two kinds of wood in their natural colours instead of paint.
Chit-thareen	Burma (entry 46)	64 squares, set high sixteen a side, carved as the things they represent	The board stands high because the players sit on the ground. The men are figures rather than tokens, red and green rather than black and white.
Chess	Morocco and England (entries 49, 50)	64 squares sixteen a side	The European game. Culin notes that its source is Arabic and that the evidence is in the words: <i>check</i> and <i>mate</i> are <i>shah mat</i> , the king is dead. He is careful to add that how it reached western Europe is not known — one of several places where he declines to fill a gap.
Tseung k'i	Canton, China (entry 51)	64 squares, divided by a blank strip called the River sixteen a side, played on the squares	The River, which the pieces must cross and which changes what some of them may do; and the marked palace of four squares crossed by diagonals in the middle of each side, inside which the general is confined.
Tjyang-keui	Korea (entry 52)	the Chinese board sixteen a side, octagonal and graded in size by value	The same board, with the files carried straight across the River, so that the River is ignored. The men are octagonal rather than round and are made larger the more valuable they are, which means the position can be read from across the room.
Shogi	Japan (entry 53)	81 slightly oblong squares wedge-shaped pieces of wood of different sizes	Nine squares each way instead of eight, and the men are punt-shaped wedges all of one colour, pointed towards the enemy — so a captured piece can change sides simply by being turned round.